27 Landscape, mobility and seasonality of the Southern Neolithic agro-pastoralists in India

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Ashmounds of the Southern Neolithic are widely understood as material expressions of pastoral movement, landscape use and the seasonal rhythms of agro-pastoral life. Their distribution, morphology and internal composition reflect decisions made across multiple scales: from daily herding routines to long-term engagements with vegetation, water and terrain. This study employs open-source QGIS software to conduct spatial analyses comparing ashmounds and associated settlements and non-associated settlements, examining their spatial and chronological relationships within broader landscape frameworks. The approach presents a reproducible QGIS-based workflow that integrates archaeobotanical evidence, micromorphological observations and regional environmental datasets to investigate how pastoral communities shaped and navigated their environments. Through multiscale spatial analysis, the research reconstructs ecological zones, grazing pathways and spatial patterns of ashmound formation, revealing how mobility, seasonality and resource availability intersected in the creation of these monumental dung accumulations. By emphasising methodological transparency and reproducible analytical procedures, the study demonstrates how open-source geospatial computing can transform heterogeneous archaeological and paleoenvironmental data into coherent interpretative models.